

According to the E-waste Management and Handling Rules that were formalised in May 2011, it became compulsory for consumers to hand over discarded electronic waste to designated collectors for proper disposal. This means that you can't simply toss that old cordless or cellphone into the bin. The rules further asked local governments to set up collection and disposal mechanisms for this purpose. The rules also made it mandatory for producers, under the extended producer responsibility, (which you will learn more about in Chapter 10) to take back e-waste for recycling. Prior to these rules the situation was abysmal. Back in 2007 Greenpeace did an Assessment of e-waste take back in India and found that 9 of the 20 brands surveyed for their takeback practice in India have no takeback service. Since then companies at least seem to have improved. Nokia for instance announces proudly on their website "In 2011 alone, we collected over 60 tons of phones and accessories through our own campaigns in India."

But there is only so much organisations can do. The change should come from within and from the masses. While disposing e-waste at an individual level the thumb rule of reduce, reuse, and recycle applies. Here are some steps you can take to ensure proper disposal of e-waste:

Reduce

This is perhaps the most difficult step in this three point program. Curbing your wants goes against the very nature of human desires. But think about it for a second. Did you really need half those purchases you made in the past year? Perhaps you could've done without that MP3 player, which is now gathering dust in your drawer. Maybe you don't need that 3D TV which everyone and their uncle seems to be harping on about. You have a 32 inch plasma at home will you really watch 3D movies wearing those dorky glasses? Each of your purchases can be evaluated in such a fashion and you will be on your way to reducing your hand in the country's e-waste production.

Reuse

There are lots of ways in which your old computers can be put to some good use. Re-using is a good way to prolong the life-cycle of a product. Just because you consider a particular piece of equipment to be obsolete and no use does not mean that there isn't someone, somewhere who would be glad to use it for a few more years. The best way is to donate it to a needy organisation. There are several organisations that accept old PCs from you.